

Mozilla to support H.264

Mozilla has reversed its stance, and will be including support for H.264 playback, at least on mobile, using system-installed codecs. <http://dgit.in/GEHGAN>



A rare update

Seagate GoFlex Satellite update allows Wi-Fi pass-through, and boosts battery life to 7 hours



Philips BDP5200

On the the front panel you find flamboyant stickers reminding you that the BD670 can do 3D. It also features integrated Wi-Fi, is DNLA capable and can play back content from an external HDD. The power key, play/pause, stop and drive eject keys are clearly highlighted in silver. The BD670 brings something that we haven't seen on any other players in this test – a cover for the USB port. While we appreciate this, the implementation has two issues. It has a flimsy build quality and the player looks ready to break after some use. Also, constantly opening it will ensure a scratched blot on the front side hurting its looks. On the back of the unit you'll find a the connectivity options, which LG hasn't shied away from – you name it and it's there. There's the component and composite video, HDMI and even the optical audio output, a LAN port and integrated Wi-Fi. Overall, the BD670 is a well put together Blu-ray player.

The most expensive dedicated Blu-ray player in this test is the Panasonic BD110. It costs considerably more than all its rivals, and for good reason. It excels in performance which we'll discuss in a while. While looks are similar to its younger sibling, the BD75 varies a bit. There's a panel that can be opened top down, or alternatively will automatically open when the drive is ejected. Hidden beneath this black door are the play/pause and stop keys. We can't really understand why these keys have been hidden away. The power

and disc eject keys are placed at the same place as the BD75, and we still believe that the two should have interchanged placement for easy user experience.

Features and Performance

Within this bunch, as we mentioned earlier, there are broadly three types of Blu-ray players: those simply running Blu-ray, ones that will play back 3D Blu-ray and players that do both as well as upscale 2D content to 3D. Let's start with the basic Blu-ray players.

Philips's BDP3200 is the first of the lot that we tested. The interface isn't all that inspiring – very basic design elements and functionality on the home screen. The upside is that you really can't go wrong with it. Moving into the settings menu brings a two-columned design, with the basic features on the left and the additional features on the right. To tweak any option, you click it and a small pop-up opens. While browsing files off a USB drive, there's the three-column layout. Neatly segregated by folders, video and audio. However, the files here aren't listed alphabetically and are randomly listed. If you connect a USB drive which has a lot of files, then it may be a time-consuming process to search for the one that you want. The player doesn't read some AVCHD files, but can handle AVI, MKV and even MP4 files quite well. Blu-ray disc performance is quite good, and the ability to change colour/picture settings between

five presets helps. However, you can't change these settings on the fly, and will have to stop video playback and go back to the home screen to access them via settings. Sadly, web services in this model are quite limited, with only YouTube available on the device. We hear that Picasa is making its way on to the Blu-ray player soon via a software upgrade. The remote is excellent – it is compact, has a clean layout and well marked keys ensure that fingers can easily remember the button placement. There's a smartphone app as well, for Android and iOS devices.

The Sony BDP-S380 is a completely different beast, on the other hand. It has the quickest starting time of the entire lot. Surprisingly, the startup times

range. There are a lot of options and setting upfront. The UI is very simple and allows you to quickly get to what you want. There's no second or third layer of screens, enhancing navigation speeds. Blu-ray picture quality is excellent, and the image is definitely crisper than what we saw on the Philips BDP3200. The remote is simple and the keys are well laid out. The lack of DivX support means that quite a few AVI videos won't play on the device. The smartphone remote app needs to be registered once with the device before it can work, a step that none of the other remote apps required.

Panasonic's DMP-BD75 is slightly on the pricier side than the Philips and Sony players. And we expected a



Panasonic DMP-BD75

vary by a few seconds every time you boot the player – with complete shutdown, unplug, plug back and restart. Once powered on, you realise that the user interface on this Blu-ray has been largely influenced by the ones on the PlayStation 3 and the new Bravia television

bit more punch for that extra buck. While it does steal the limelight from Sony, thanks to the latter's inexplicable removal of DivX support, the Philips Blu-ray player is still a step ahead. While Blu-ray disc playback is essentially the same in terms of quality, the BD75



LG BD670